in the wake of your leave

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/71063026.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Character Death, Loss of Parent(s), Grief/Mourning, inheriting a pet from a deceased loved one, Fluff and Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Friends to Lovers, mydei acts of service guy because I said so, Mutual Pining, Healing

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-09-19 Words: 11,111 Chapters: 1/1

in the wake of your leave

by FingerCracc

Summary

The rustle of fabric, the sound of a sigh. Something warm is draped around Phainon’s shoulders. A blood-red, shiny coat. The inside is terribly soft, and that smell—Mydei’s smell—clings to it too. “At least wear a jacket if you’re going to be stubborn,” he says, and he’s still standing there when Phainon turns his head to look. He’s left in a tight black t-shirt, arms bare and folded against the chill, ruffled but pretending not to be.

Phainon’s chest hurts. “What about you?” he asks.

“I’m fine,” Mydei says.

“You’re shivering.”
|
Phainon loses his parents, gains a cat and a boyfriend, and not much changes at all.

Notes

I wrote much of this while listening to Gang of Youths' angel in realtime. beautiful beautiful beautiful album on grief

See the end of the work for more notes

After a dozen conversations and the first snow beginning to fall, Phainon steps outside. The screen door to the back porch squeals a little as he pushes it open. More when he closes it. They've had this window open all night in hopes of offsetting the oven being on and the body heat of so many people. It's stuffy anyway, loud with laughter, sticky with sweat. Phainon folds his arms over the wooden railing to the back porch and turns his face up to watch the sky.

It's already dark, though it's barely 7PM. The beginning of winter will do that. A sky thick with gray clouds, dusk blue, thin flakes of snow floating down and melting as soon as they touch the ground. In the light spilling from the open window, there's Aglaea's dead grass, the white picket fence at the edge of the yard, a couple of bare trees and empty planter boxes she'll fill with squash and tomatoes and cantaloupe in the spring.

It's a bit cold. Phainon's breath fogs up in the air before him. He shivers, curls in on himself just a bit. He left his coat inside.

Moments pass, minutes. He watches the play of light pooling on the porch. Red brown wood in neatly aligned planks. There's a tiny chip in one spot. A knot in the wood in another. The snow falls a little faster now. Still small flakes, but enough that some might stick before the night is over. For now it still melts on contact, and Phainon still watches, and laughter still comes from inside.

How long before someone notices he's missing? He should go back. Laugh and say he just needed some air. He did, he does. A quarter past 7, and he's already tired.

The screen door screams open again. A shadow falls across the patch of leaking light. Footsteps cause the deck to creak. "Too fucking hot in there," Mydei grumbles, settling at Phainon's side, hands curling over the railing. His coat is blood red and shiny with waterproofing. This close, he smells faintly like the eggplant parmesan casserole he'd spent a good part of the day making for Castorice's birthday party.

Phainon hunches a little, propped on his elbows, wood grain biting into his forearms. “You’d think it would be cooler this late in the season,” he notes. There’s the rustle of cloth as Mydei shifts, looks at him.

“Basically winter, with the snow,” he says, and his voice is kind of quiet. Phainon hums, a cloud of his breath dissipating. His arms are prickly with gooseflesh. A fresh round of laughter comes from inside; Anaxa’s, loud and borderline hysterical. Mydei sighs just to see it turn to fog, a childish habit he won’t admit to. “It’s late this year, isn’t it?”

“Still a month to the solstice,” Phainon tells him. “It’s still fall, technically.”

A grunt, and then silence. Phainon catches a couple of snowflakes in his palm, connects their droplets with the tip of his finger when they melt. “You’re shivering, idiot,” Mydei observes. “Where’s your coat?”

“Inside,” Phainon answers. “I was hot.” He was and he wasn’t. Half lie, half truth. He’s fairly certain Mydei can see through him like glass. But of all the people to be seen by, Mydei isn’t a bad choice. Phainon is so tired.

Mydei scoffs, but it’s soft. “Come back in,” he says. “Cas is missing you.”

Phainon takes a slow inhale. It’s cold enough that his nose might start to run. After his exhale dissipates, he folds forward, dropping his head on his arms, hunched all awkward with too much height. “She can do without me for a bit,” he murmurs.

A handful of seconds go by, slow-paced and shivering. Curled up as he is, Phainon watches his own chest rise and fall, maps the ripples and folds in his shirt. Somewhere in there is an aching, hollow core.

The rustle of fabric, the sound of a sigh. Something warm is draped around Phainon’s shoulders. A blood-red, shiny coat. The inside is terribly soft, and that smell—Mydei’s smell—clings to it too. “At least wear a jacket if you’re going to be stubborn,” he says, and he’s still standing there when Phainon turns his head to look. He’s left in a tight black t-shirt, arms bare and folded against the chill, ruffled but pretending not to be.

Phainon’s chest hurts. He hooks a finger in the collar of Mydei’s coat, pulling it a little tighter around himself. “Maybe half freezing to death is the vibe I’m going for,” he tries. At Mydei’s glare, he offers weak laughter. He’s so tired, but this doesn’t tire him. This is nice. Unspoken comfort. Understanding and the care enough to do little things that help.

“Shut the fuck up,” Mydei tells him, and he’s the one shivering now. Warmed from the outside in, there’s a small glow in Phainon’s chest.

“What about you?” he asks.

“I’m fine,” Mydei says.

“You’re shivering.”

They bump. Mydei makes him straighten up so they’re looking at each other eye-to-eye. “Should’ve thought of that before you robbed me of my coat at gunpoint,” he says, and he gives this tiny smile when it makes Phainon laugh. He’s still shivering, hands tucked under his armpits to keep them from freezing, breath still fogging up. He’s been here for a while. Phainon has loved him for a while.

“My bad,” he chuckles, playing along, fingers twisting in the waterproof fabric. Snow alights on Mydei’s hair. There isn’t much light to catch it. “I didn’t think you needed it.”

A huff, a laugh, Mydei shakes his head. “I’m going in,” he says. “We’re probably cutting the cake soon. And…” He pauses, studies Phainon’s expression, whatever that may be. “...In case some stupid part of your pebble-sized brain wasn’t sure of it, everyone noticed that you were gone, and everyone cared. Not just me.”

As he rolls the screen door open and disappears inside, Phainon watches his back, exhales sharply. Feels an odd sting in the back of his throat like he might cry.

△

In the end, he comes back to the party, nose running, snow on the shoulders of Mydei's coat. He brushes it out of his hair. The lightest dusting of it sticks on the lawn.

He hangs up the coat. Faces himself in the mirror above the sofa in Aglaea's living room. He's flushed from the cold. There are dark circles like bruises beneath his eyes. His hair is a bit flat, but maybe that's the wetness from the melted snow. He smiles, just for practice. He finds the rest of them gathered and packed like sardines in the dining room.

He isn't questioned, and for that, he's grateful. Hyacine insists on them all singing happy birthday to Castorice while she flushes and blows out her candles. They cut the cake, laugh and chat and eat. It's still hot inside from the cooking and the body heat, but it's nice now. Phainon had grown used to the cold and forgotten what it felt like not to shiver.

Mydei's hand on his shoulder. Sweet frosting on his tongue. Plush cream-colored carpet. He drinks half a beer and stops because it turns his stomach. Cipher gets them playing card games, and he has fun. Being here with all of his closest friends in a room filled with laughter, he has fun. As the night stretches long, he starts to feel a little bit sick with it. Guilty, though he knows it's a wretched, irrational way to feel.

But how can he smile? How can he laugh? How can he be happy like this with his life in ruins at his feet?

Something prods his upper arm. Mydei in focus, up close under warm-toned ceiling lights. His eyes are lined in red and that tiny section of hair is braided behind his ear as it always is. "It's your turn, dumbass," he tells Phainon.

He's less severe, lately. Softer, as Phainon is subdued. It's nice that he doesn't make it feel like pity. "Ah." Phainon turns his gaze to his cards, puts one down, tries to focus back on this. Aglaea is next, wordless as she sets something down. On to Castorice. Hyacine stands briefly to close the window as the chill finally starts to creep in. Phainon watches. A little bit more snow has stuck, a half-inch of waterlogged powder clinging to the ground. It's more slush than snow, still trying to melt as it touches the earth.

Hyacine pulls the curtains shut and returns to her spot just in time for her turn after Anaxa. Phainon looks at Mydei, finds him already looking back. His expression is neutral, but his thoughts are probably not. He's attentive in a strange kind of way. Phainon pulls his cards close to his chest. "You're not trying to cheat, are you?" he asks. Mydei's eyes narrow. He scoffs and turns away.

The rest of the night goes on like this. They play a few games. Talk and laugh some more. Aglaea and Mydei disappear to wrap up the leftover cake and dinner, and then they're yawning and grumbling about work in the morning.

Phainon pulls on his coat, pats his pockets to make sure he has everything, and steps back into the cold. He has to be careful as he walks. Farewells are thrown out, echoing in the air. There's a smile on his face. Mydei grabs his arm.

"I'll drive you," he says. Phainon doesn't even have a chance to ask.

His car is cold and leather-smelling, a dime-sized rock chip in the windshield. Phainon slides into the passenger side and clips his seatbelt into place. "Thank you," he says.

Mydei starts the car, looks at him cast in shadows and grunts. The sound of tires on slush. He looks away. Phainon plays with the fur lining in his sleeve as he watches out the window. House after house with the lights off. Streetlights reflecting off the still falling snow. Not a single star in the sky. It's kind of lonely. No more laughter in the background, just the stillness of night.

"Do you go back to work tomorrow?" Mydei asks after a while. His thumb taps on the steering wheel. The radio is off, but the car hums steadily.

"I do," Phainon tells him. Better this way regardless. It's no use for him to sit at home and drive himself insane. Better to do something useful. Better to have a way to pass the time. "I'm not happy about it but I think it'll be better for me than sitting around."

Silently, Mydei nods. He reaches for the knob to start the heater now that the car has had a chance to warm up. The rush of the air, tires through slush. Phainon takes a breath, lets it out slowly. He's already lonely with ten minutes to home. "I have too many leftovers," Mydei says. "I'll drop them off after you get home tomorrow."

A small, tired smile finds its way onto his face. "'Leftovers,' he says, like he isn't going to cook three brand new dishes just for this."

A moment of quiet. He watches Mydei clench his jaw, wet his lips. "The batches will be big," he amends, "I'll have too many leftovers."

"Ah," Phainon says, and his exhale is half a laugh. "That makes a lot of sense. Those batches are just… so hard to make smaller."

"So I have to share," Mydei agrees, playing along as he always does, "or it'll go to waste." Again, Phainon laughs a little. Again, Mydei glances at him. Just briefly, so briefly with his attention still on the road. Softer, while Phainon is still subdued.

"I appreciate you," Phainon tells him. A lump forms in his throat. Quieter, "A lot." He can't cook for himself these days. He can hardly bring himself to do the dishes or laundry or drag himself outside to feel the sun. It's been a week and he's still in shambles.

"Don't bother with that," Mydei grumbles. "Only a shallow, shitty friend does things for thanks."

"Funny," Phainon says, and his voice is all weird, "I don't seem to recall thanking you."

"Semantics."

"You're ridiculous."

"And you're naive."

The edges of his window start to fog up. Phainon traces a face with his finger, glances at Mydei, stubborn and still driving. "So ridiculous. Just say

‘I’m glad I can help’ and move on.”

Mydei’s nostrils flare, his grip on the wheel tightens. He’s quiet for a handful of long, stretching moments. Phainon figures the conversation is over. Can’t find anything in him to say. Mydei finally opens his mouth. “It frustrates me that I can’t do more.”

“You’re doing plenty.”

He sighs. He’s silent. It’s a warm feeling, to be cared about by him. Phainon plays with his coat, cold fingers twisting in it. His chin trembles. He presses his lips tight together as the emotion eases. To have someone like this on his side. To be loved, even in the midst of grief.

“I mean it,” he murmurs. “I appreciate you.”

He watches Mydei’s throat bob as he swallows. Listens to his silence. “I’m… glad,” Mydei says. Begrudgingly.

Phainon sniffs, smiles, turns toward the window to hide it as he blots at his eyes with the edge of his sleeve. Three minutes to home, to the coldness of his own walls and creaking pipes. He’ll fall asleep lonely. He tries not to worry about tomorrow.

△

His sleep is fitful, but it’s enough. Work passes as usual, a pile of tasks ready and waiting. A few coworkers ask after him and his family. He smiles and thanks them for their concern. He gets good at that, gets practiced at saying *I’m doing as well as I can* over and over, to a dozen different people.

And he is. After a while, he manages to settle back into his role, and the work is familiar and demanding enough to distract him. He’s still tired, still heavy, but it’s enough.

At some point during the day, he misses a call from an unknown number. He’s been answering those every time he can lately. Just in case, just on the off chance someone will call because they’d seen one of the posters Mydei

had helped him plaster high and low across his hometown. But the days stretch on and after the snowfall last night, Phainon has struggled to hold out hope.

There's a voicemail that he listens to in the parking lot before he heads home. Forty-six seconds long. He turns his volume up and hits play. Immediately, there's the crackle of static.

"He— Um. Hi, this is Livia. Hopefully this is the right number; I got it off a missing cat poster on my mailbox. I believe I found…" The rustle of paper. *"Bubbles. He was scratching at my door during the snow last night and I let him in. It was late so… But he's still here, and I'm sure you're missing him, so call me back at this number when you can."*

A smoking, charcoal house. Soot on his fingers as he tried to sort through the surviving things. His own voice, raw as he's ever heard it asking again and again. *Have you seen their cat? He's gray and white with the biggest blue eyes. He's probably terrified, please—*

His hands are shaking. He plays the voicemail again just to be sure he heard it right, and there it is, this girl's voice saying it: *I believe I found Bubbles, I believe I found Bubbles, I believe I found Bubbles.* His parents' dumb cat. Fingers covered in paper cuts and ink from the posters. Mydei's neutral expression as he took half the stack and a roll of tape from Phainon's hands without a word. Night after night spent wondering, *where are you?*

Four days after the funeral, Phainon gets this call, and he gets his answer. He exhales, folds in on himself until his forehead knocks into his steering wheel. His chest is robbed of breath; his hands are still shaking. He calls Livia back. It rings once, twice, three, four times.

"Hello?"

"Hi," Phainon says, heavy and breathless at once. A beat. "I hear you have my cat."

"Bubbles, right?" Livia asks. She sounds young. She sounds apologetic and excited both. "Yes, I have him holed up in my bathroom for now so he's not

out in the cold. I have another cat so it's… Well."

"I'm sorry," he murmurs. His voice is unsteady. He hates that he sounds like this, tries clearing his throat.

"No, don't be!" Livia protests. "He's been very sweet, really. I have a huge soft spot for cats, so it's no trouble at all. Are you… able to come pick him up?"

He doesn't trust his voice. His head against the steering wheel, his phone in his lap. "Yeah," he says, as level as he can manage. "I'm a ways away, but I'll be there as soon as I can."

So he hangs up with an address in his phone and a rumbling stomach. Mydei was going to bring dinner. It'll have to wait in the wake of this. His parents' stupid cat. The last thing he has left of them.

He's crying. He doesn't even know why, but he's crying. They're silent tears, but for the sharpness of his breath and the sniffling. He wipes his eyes on his arm, still hunched, still shaking. "Ah, fuck," he tries, knocking his head against the steering wheel once, twice, and accidentally setting the horn off. It's jarring enough to make him laugh, sitting up straight and scrubbing his eyes again.

The drive is an hour and ten minutes in rush hour traffic. When his eyes are dry and his breath is stable, he calls Mydei next. It connects after a single ring.

"What is it?" Mydei asks. He's steady as anything. Phainon settles in, buckles his seatbelt.

"You'll have to bring your 'leftovers' tomorrow," he says. "Someone found Bubbles."

△

The drive feels like an age. Phainon's hands are white-knuckled on the wheel. The road is backed up with cars. He inches along at thirty-three

miles an hour on the freeway, stomach turning, thoughts stuck on *where have you been? Why did it take so long to find you? How terrified must you be to come home and find nothing but ash?*

He's been clenching his jaw without realizing. His teeth ache. Just a bit further. Just the rest of today, and the rest of the work week, and then he can breathe.

Livia is just as kind and just as awkward in person as she was over the phone. Her smile is apologetic like she hasn't done Phainon the most impactful favor he's received in years. Like she hasn't saved his parents' stupid cat.

"Do you have a carrier for him?" she asks, and Phainon feels his stomach drop.

"Shit," he says. He doesn't have one. He doesn't have a goddamn cat. "I forgot."

Again, she just smiles. This anxious, insistent energy fills Phainon's veins, stagnant without outlet, making his fists clench, his teeth close around the inside of his cheek. But he listens as she speaks, because the only real alternatives are running a lap around her circle or sinking to the floor to hide his head in his knees and rock back and forth like an upset child. "It's okay," she tells him. "I kept the cardboard one they gave me when I adopted my own a couple years ago. You can take that."

He wonders what he looks like to her. Sure, he knows her brand of socially awkward—apologetic and overly accommodating for fear of making mistakes—but he's seen his own face. His dark circles, his strained smile, his grief etched into every line. He must seem a pitiable creature.

"Thank you," he tries, and that comes out too grateful, too weary, like the challenge of hunting down some other solution is too much for his exhausted bones. Again, she smiles. Again, it's terribly apologetic.

"I'll, um. Get him now. If you don't mind waiting a bit."

“Yeah,” Phainon says, “not at all.”

She doesn’t invite him inside. He doesn’t ask. When the door shuts again between them, Phainon stands, and then he sinks to hug his knees on her neatly decorated front porch. A fall wreath on her front door, wilting pumpkins left from Halloween on every step on the way up. He shuts his eyes, takes a deep breath, knocks his forehead into his knees. A moment passes, two. He straightens up before she can come back out and see what a fragile fool he is.

It’s cold and bitter out here. His fingers are chilled. His throat aches where his jacket doesn’t manage to cover it. Out in the street, a line of garbage cans sits in the center of the circle. He waits, waits, waits. Watches an autumn colored leaf fall off a bare-bones tree and float to the ground. The snow has all melted by now. It’s just brown-gray earth and white-cloud sky. This season is hard for him every year.

She comes out a minute later. There’s the sound of the door creaking open and a cat yowling like the end of days has come. Livia looks frantic and embarrassed as Bubble cries and cries and scratches at his cardboard prison, and Phainon can do nothing but take a breath in and laugh wetly.

“That’s him,” he says as Livia sets the box between them. Bubbles turns around inside, fur scraping the walls, and he isn’t visible through the holes cut into the sides of the box, but Phainon would know that meow anywhere. He’s never heard a cat so raspy. It’s a terribly ugly sound. His vision blurs with wetness.

“Can I…” She sounds stressed, probably because Bubbles is still screaming. “Can I help with anything else? I’m sorry, he’s probably terrified since I just… snatched him up and put him in there. I tried not to scare him, but—”

“It’s okay,” Phainon tells her. This stupid, stupid cat. His throat is all tight. He tries to clear it. “He’s always been dramatic, don’t worry about it. I’m really grateful that you found him and took care of him.”

Livia blinks at him, hovers in the doorway. She chews on her lip, nods. “Of course,” she says. “Like I said, I… have a soft spot…”

“Right.” Phainon takes a half step forward, lifts the box as steadily as he can in one hand. The balance tips and shifts as Bubbles moves inside, not quieting for a second. “Well, thank you again. I’ve got him from here.”

“You’re welcome,” she tells him. Awkwardly, “Drive safe.”

“Thank you,” he says again. They smile, nod, she shuts the door between them as he turns to take careful steps down the stairs, trying his best not to jostle the cat.

He buckles Bubbles into the backseat, the position of the seatbelt a bit awkward but the best he can do. And then he sinks into a squat with the door still open and folds his arms along the seat. “You’re okay, bud,” he whispers, brow falling onto his forearms. Briefly, the yowling stops. He sighs, sniffles. His lower lip trembles. Another meow, softer this time, like Bubbles has tired himself out. “I know,” he breathes, lifting his head and poking a finger through one of the holes for the cat to sniff. “It’s almost over; I’ve got you.”

A lone tear slips down his cheek. He wipes it on the back of his hand, whispers a curse. A moment longer, he forces himself to stand and climb into the driver’s seat. A deep breath to collect himself. His hands shake as he scrubs at his face again and starts the car.

The drive home feels like an age as well, though it has to be shorter with only the tail end of rush hour left. Bubbles cries the entire time. Phainon’s knuckles go white. His stomach twists, twists, twists. His hands have cramped by the time he pulls into his parking space. His chest caves in with his exhale. He hasn’t paid a pet deposit. He doesn’t even think he can afford it right now. He’s half certain every resident in the building hears Bubbles cry on the way up to his apartment.

Door shut, he sets the box on the floor, undoes the flaps holding it closed, and for the first time after a week of grief, he meets the wide blue eyes of this tiny creature, the last thing he has left of his parents. Gray and white

fur, the pinkest little nose, whiskers peppered white and black both. Bubbles stares at him for all of three seconds before he jumps out of the box and darts straight under the couch.

Phainon watches him go and sinks to his ass on the floor, folding his arms around himself, trying to breathe. He doesn't know what he's doing. He's never been responsible for another living creature, but the thought of shipping Bubbles off to some shelter has him sick. Even just offering him up to a family friend or a neighbor feels wrong, wrong, wrong.

This stupid fucking cat. He has a track record of tearing up furniture and barging in on guests in the bathroom. He'll bite ankles and scratch at walls and find a way to eat any houseplant no matter how inaccessible it is. He has the ugliest meow. He's the meanest, most frustrating cat Phainon has ever met. Phainon can't even afford to keep him. And yet.

He unlocks his phone, still here on the floor. Presses call. It connects after the first ring.

"He's home," Phainon murmurs. "Just in case you were worried."

Quiet on the other end. A beat, two. "Are you even equipped to take care of a cat?" Mydei asks. "He needs a litterbox, toys, food."

There hadn't been much to salvage from the home. Phainon kept very little, but there'd been half a bag of kibble and a laser pointer he'd pocketed just in case. "I know," he says. His head is throbbing. It's late. His stomach growls. He's so tired. "I'm going to the pet store next."

"He's gonna shit on the floor if you wait too long."

"I know," Phainon repeats, grinding his forehead into his knees. A breath, then another. "I'm going."

"They close in forty-five," Mydei tells him. "Better hurry."

Again, still on the floor, Bubbles still hidden out of sight, "I'm going."

△

Mydei is there when Phainon comes back, sitting in front of his door on his welcome mat, red coat folded over his lap, a plastic grocery bag by his leg and his phone in hand. The hallway is yellow with artificial light and smelling faintly of onion, and Phainon comes to a stop in front of him, nudging his knee with his foot, both hands full.

Mydei looks up, face washed clean of makeup this late, honest with pale eyelashes and dark circles. “You’re slow as fuck, you know that?” he says, standing, shoving his phone in his pocket, bag crinkling in his grip.

“You didn’t say you were coming,” Phainon points out. He frees a hand to unlock the door. The apartment is still and silent as they head inside. They make a ruckus, stumbling, crinkling plastic bags. Phainon sets down his things. A new litterbox and scooper, a set of bowls, a case of canned cat food. He’ll feel the strain on his bank account. He’ll have to cut out the majority of his personal spending this month.

“I didn’t have enough hands to get the litter too,” he says, glancing at Mydei, studying him in this space. Mydei, who’s always here. “Would you hold the door for me?”

So Mydei holds the door open for him as he comes back from his second trip, two bags of cat litter in his arms. He doesn’t make any snide comments. Maybe Phainon is making things up, but he always seems softer without that bold red eyeliner. Maybe it’s just cold and late. Most people are softer in the dark. But then, this is Mydei. Soft as Phainon is subdued. Quietly understanding, offering unspoken comfort.

They set up the litterbox in the bathroom together. There isn’t much space for it, tucked tightly into the corner next to the bathtub. They turn the bathmat vertical instead of horizontal to make space. Phainon will have to squeeze there on his way out of the shower. It’ll probably end up full of litter after a day or two, and he’ll have to decide whether he wants to deal with shaking it out every day or not having a bathmat at all. Bubbles still doesn’t show himself. Phainon wants to sink down and hug his knees again, but Mydei is here, so he doesn’t.

He finally eats dinner. Late, late, late, Mydei's 'leftover' lasagna. The first few bites remind him that he's hungry enough for it to hurt. Exhausted enough to fall asleep right there. Aching enough to cry.

"This is good," he says instead.

Mydei's gaze flicks up. He's weird about praise. He's always been weird about praise. "There're two more servings in the fridge," he says, instead of something normal, like *thank you.* "And I'm expecting those containers back."

"I'm not a thief, Mydeimos," Phainon tries, smiling a little. Just a little; he's still so tired. It's still an effort he has to force. That tiny voice repeating over and over, *how can I smile at all?*

"So you say."

He sighs through his nose, shakes his head. His fork clinks against the nice glass container he eats out of. Mydei always uses glass. He claims that everything tastes worse in plastic, but Phainon has never noticed.

A string of cheese stretches from his next bite. He chews slowly. Probably wouldn't be eating at all if Mydei hadn't come. Part of him wants to ask why he's here. Past nine on a worknight, doing manual labor and sharing his home-cooked lasagna with an emotionally unstable shell of a man. Phainon isn't good company these days, he knows. Mydei would be having a lot more fun elsewhere. And yet here he is. And there he was, saying *it frustrates me that I can't do more.* Putting his coat around Phainon's cold shoulders. Driving him home.

"I appreciate you," Phainon tells him again, because he thinks Mydei would rather hear that than *I'm sorry.* But he's always been weird about praise, so maybe he'll gripe again and talk about how no good friend should do things for thanks. Like that doesn't mean he deserves them anyway. Like Phainon hasn't loved him for god knows how long by now.

But he just looks away and says, "...I'm glad I could help," like it turns his stomach. His ears go red. Phainon's chest squeezes. He lets out a weak

laugh.

“Look at you,” he says, “you’re learning.”

“You’re just going to bitch at me again if I say what I really want to say,” Mydei grumbles. “I’m saving us both the hassle.”

I love you, Phainon thinks. He’s so tired. It’s nice, having a place to rest. *You’re wonderful at loving me too.* “You’re ridiculous,” he says.

“And you’re terribly uncreative,” Mydei tells him. “Using the same insult over and over only tires it out rather than making it true.”

“Ridiculous,” Phainon repeats, laughing a little, easier this time. “Stay?”

Mydei softens, if only a bit. “I work in the morning,” he says. His work shoes and his badge to get in the building will be back at his own place. If he stays, he’ll have to wake up early just to go back home anyway. Pointless, Phainon knows. He sighs. At times, when he isn’t terribly glad to have his privacy and the ability to set all his own rules, he misses living at home. It’s a lonely feeling, coming home to nothing and no one.

“Ah,” Phainon says. “I forgot.”

Mydei’s hand twisting his fork. Red lines tattooed on his forearms. In his gruff, Mydei way, he seems apologetic. “You work too, idiot.”

He hums, takes another bite. It’s good. Phainon can cook for himself, but he never does. He can’t find the motivation when it’s just *him* to take care of. Lately, he can’t find the motivation to do much at all.

“How was that, by the way?” Mydei asks. “Going back today.”

“Fine,” Phainon answers. Metal on glass. He reaches for his water, takes a sip. “Hard. Annoying. I don’t know. I just wanted to go home.”

“Long day.”

“Long fucking week.” Phainon sighs. Maybe two bites left of his food. Mydei’s already finished. “You should head back if you’re going to get some sleep tonight.” Nice, having him for a little while. Coming home to him on his doorstep. He’ll fall asleep and wake up lonely, but at least this was nice.

“Did you feed the cat?” Mydei asks.

Phainon swallows the last of his lasagna. His fork clinks as he sets it down. “No,” he says. “He hasn’t come out.”

“He’ll be hungry,” Mydei reminds him, chair scraping as he stands. He stacks the dishes, gathers them up. “You do that. I’ll do this.”

“I can wash my own dishes.”

“I’m aware,” is all Mydei says before he turns and heads to the kitchen, leaving Phainon alone under the artificial light at his tiny dining table. Phainon watches his back. The folds in his loose white t-shirt. The hair at the nape of his neck. His sigh is heavy. Finding the strength to stand takes an age. He gathers his bags from the pet store and joins Mydei in the kitchen. He has the tap on, rinsing the sauce from the containers.

“Should I try wet food to lure him out, or dry in case he lets it sit for a while before he comes out to eat?” Phainon wonders. There’s a fragile, wavering feeling in his chest. His swallow is thick. “I don’t know anything about cats. What if he just never comes out?”

“Be serious,” Mydei tells him. “He’s in a new environment after losing his home and being tossed around a bunch. Of course he’s scared. He’ll come out once he realizes he’s safe.”

He exhales, shaky. “And how will he *know?*”

“You’re here,” Mydei says, like it’s really that simple. “He knows you; he’ll figure it out pretty quick.”

Phainon goes for dry food instead of wet. Patience is probably key. Bubbles doesn't come out when coaxed, but he meows and lets Phainon reach a hand under the couch to pet him, so it's only a matter of time. He leaves the bowl with another full of water on the living room floor and lays there a little longer, watching the light reflect off Bubbles' eyes. He blinks slowly, because his mom always told him to do that.

It's like telling him you're a friend, she'd say. *If he does it back, that means he's a friend too.*

Bubbles just stares for a long while, but after a handful of moments he finally does it back. Phainon's chest squeezes. He reaches his hand back under the couch and gently scratches Bubbles under the chin. He's so soft. So little. Phainon turns his eyes against his arm, pulling his hand back and grabbing a fistful of his own hair.

Damn it, he thinks. *God fucking damn it.*

The floor creaks. He rolls over, and there's Mydei standing over him, the two clean containers stacked in his hand. "I'm heading out," he says, studying Phainon for a moment. His expression is calm and impassive. A fist closes around Phainon's heart.

"Drive safe," he says, cold and tired and heavy-limbed. He traces the ceiling patterns with his eyes, watches as Mydei sinks into a squat and a hand finds his hair, carding it off his forehead.

"Let me know," Mydei says, "if you're worried about anything. With Bubbles or whatever." His fingers are warm, smelling like dish soap.

"You shouldn't say that," Phainon tells him. His shoulder blades against the faux wood. His back is starting to hurt. "I'll just blow up your phone all day."

A half smile at this. Mydei pulls through Phainon's bangs until the ends slip from his fingers. "Use your best judgment," he says, poking Phainon in the center of the forehead. "I know you struggle with that."

Phainon laughs, swats his hand away. “Ridiculous,” he says as Mydei stands up. “You’re ridiculous, Mydeimos.”

The plastic bag rustles as he grabs it, nudging his foot into Phainon’s shoulder. “And your insults have no bite. Bye, Phainon.”

“Bye,” Phainon says back, watching him turn and go, hearing the sound of his footsteps. *Thank you,* he almost adds. *I love you.* Instead, he listens to the door shut. Feels his smile linger and fade. Sighs, softly, turning his head, hair all messed up from Mydei’s hands, and meets Bubbles’ eyes again. “Just you and me now,” he whispers, blinking slowly. “Just… you and me.”

△

In the morning, the food bowl is empty, there’s foul-smelling, unburied cat shit in the litterbox, and Bubbles has vacated the space beneath the couch. Phainon doesn’t have time to search the corners of his house for the cat before work, so he just changes out the water and refills the food and heads out.

There’s traffic on the way there, more on the way back. Phainon is already worn out and ready to go home by the time he steps foot in the building. A coworker greets him politely in the hallway. He smiles something practiced and friendly and wonders where he’ll find the strength to make it through today.

But he does. He always does. He fakes smiles and makes pleasant small talk and gets his work done. At times, it’s a good distraction for the feeling in his chest. At others, it’s all he can do to not waste his time off to go home and rot in his sheets. But he makes it, and a little past 4:30 PM he clocks out and pushes the doors open to the outside where the air is cold and breezy. It punches through his autumn jacket. He’ll have to start wearing his full winter coat soon.

He comes home to no one on his doorstep and nothing waiting for him. His keys jingle as he fumbles for the right one. Leftover lasagna and the warmth of his blankets. Maybe he’ll start watching that show Cipher can’t shut up

about. Maybe he'll crack open the book he hasn't touched in over a week. It's due at the library in a few days. He'll have to renew it or give it back.

He gets the door open and is greeted by dust motes and dying daylight through the windows. Silence, stillness. He shuts the door behind him and takes off his shoes, exhaling. Finally home with the space to breathe and a feeling in the pit of his stomach heavy enough to crush a person from the inside out.

He hangs up his bag, leaves his keys in the bowl beside the door. The clink of that, the creak of the floor, the distant hum of the heater. "I'm home," Phainon murmurs to no one. A beat passes. A meow answers him back.

"Bubbles?"

Again. High, raspy, insistent. Phainon follows the sound around the flat, not really sure where it's coming from. A spill of water from the bowl left in the living room. The smell of cat shit wafting from the bathroom. And there, amidst the mess of Phainon's unmade bed, Bubbles has made a nest for himself. Gray and white, paws tucked beneath his tiny body, eyes as big and blue as anything. He sniffs obligingly when Phainon sinks to his knees and holds out a hand. Blinks slow and sits there like he'd never been afraid at all. Phainon can't do much more than laugh, ducking his head into his arms and setting his hand on Bubbles' head. He scratches, softly. Bubbles leans into it, heavy and light as air in Phainon's palm.

"Ah, fuck," Phainon breathes. The darkness behind his eyelids. The softness of Bubbles' fur under his fingers. They haven't gotten to the part where his furniture gets torn up and he steps in puddles of barf and gets his ankles nipped yet, and Phainon knows all of those things are coming, and he knows that keeping this dumb cat is financially inadvisable, but this…

He knows you, Mydei had said. Phainon had replayed the words over and over in his head trying to fall asleep last night. *He knows you, he knows you, he knows you.*

You're the only thing he has left of them too.

And that, just that one thought is enough to make the choice for him. He's keeping this stupid fucking cat. Everything else be damned.

A purr rumbles from Bubbles' chest. He licks Phainon's wrist as he accepts his scratches, rough like sandpaper, his breath stinking and fishy. Phainon's next exhale shakes in his chest, a laugh or a sob. When he looks up, his face must be too close for Bubbles' liking, because he takes a swat straight to the cheek.

△

Wednesday passes the same. Phainon works and comes home. Cleans Bubbles' litterbox. Tries and fails to use the laser pointer to play with him. Bubbles just licks his paw and ignores it no matter what he does.

He takes refuge in Phainon's room now. Maybe it's the familiar smell or just the fact that his mess of blankets is comfortable. He gets fur all over Phainon's sheets, but it doesn't seem worth it to kick him out. Not when he'll just go back as soon as Phainon is out. Not when he's soft and warm and likes to purr and sleep curled in the space behind Phainon's knees at night.

He's clingy now that he's comfortable. He swats at Phainon for attention and bites him when he receives one pet too many, and he's expensive, and he never buries his poop, and his meow is still one of the ugliest sounds on earth, but when he's here, curled up at Phainon's hip, a paw on his thigh, purring up a storm and licking him as he gives him scratches… It's a little bit less lonely. There's someone waiting for him to come home. There's someone who feels his loss just as keenly as he does. Someone who needs him.

It's harder to rot and to wallow when he's needed. He has a reason to get up when Bubbles needs to be fed. It's easy to remember to feed himself after too.

He sends Cipher Bubbles photos. Reads some of Castorice's poetry when she sends it. Lets Mydei pester him into getting groceries. He's still exhausted. Still a little hollow on the inside and aching, but it's a normal

enough day that he can drag himself through it. Just for a while, just until that voice comes back, whispering in his head.

How can you smile, how can you laugh? How can you live after it all?

But he does. He starts to grow used to it. He presses his ear to Bubbles' side when the cat is in one of his better moods and lets the sound of his purring rumble through him. It's a bit like healing, at least in this instant. He's feeling terribly nostalgic, but some of the memories are more sweet than bitter. He goes through the motions. Life goes on.

△

Thursday marks a week since the funeral. Phainon wakes to his alarm with a paw on his forehead. Bubbles sits on his pillow, eyes still shut. A breath in. Phainon sits up and shuts the sound off. His blankets pool around him. It's cold with skin exposed to air. He rubs his eyes and folds forward until his head hits the mattress.

It takes a bit, but with a raspy meow from a now-awake and ready to be fed cat, he resigns himself to another day. Breakfast, getting ready, work, lunch, more work, finally going home. A text from Mydei from two hours ago that he only sees when he unlocks his phone to queue up music for the drive home. *Dinner at mine?* is all it says.

One week. Another deep breath, just to try to fill that hollow in his chest. *I'm visiting the grave tonight,* he sends back. *Sorry I didn't see.*

He's out of lasagna. Mydei's containers are washed clean and stacked neatly on his counter. He'll find time to return them. Maybe over the weekend, when he has enough time that the smallest thing after work doesn't feel insurmountable.

Three dots. Head against the steering wheel, he waits for a reply that comes quick. *Want company?*

He presses call, and Mydei answers before the first ring is done. "It's a question," he says. "If that's personal and you'd rather go alone just say so.

Don’t be dramatic.”

A tight feeling in his throat. Phainon laughs a little, his phone in his lap and the leather seams on the steering wheel biting into his forehead. “I love you,” he says, voice breaking on it. There’s an inhale on the other end. Silence. “I really do.”

“Phainon.”

“I don’t think you realize how warm and supportive you’ve been.” He sniffs, realizes he’s crying again. Crying for the hundredth time since he got the news. But this time it’s good. “You brush it all off but it means so much to me. And I try to say that, but I don’t know if you really get it. So just… Thank you. I love you. I appreciate you.”

Mydei is still quiet. Stunned to silence. “...So you’ve said,” he manages after a bit, tentative and lost.

“Just tell me you get it,” Phainon says, eyes still shut. “Tell me you understand and I’ll shut up.”

“I get it,” Mydei tells him. “I’m… glad I can help.”

He smiles. Takes a breath deep enough to make his lungs hurt. “I won’t make you come unless you really want to,” he says. “Just… Thank you for offering.”

Another pause. He’s sure Mydei doesn’t know what to do with him. This sad, sentimental version of him. But he’s softer where Phainon is subdued, and he makes effort after effort. The sturdiest rock, the warmest shoulder. Phainon’s never had someone be there for him quite like this. It’s a feeling everyone deserves to have.

“I forget the address,” Mydei says.

Phainon lets out a breath and says, “I’ll send it.”

△

Mydei brings flowers to Phainon's parents' grave. Slim white roses and baby's breath framed by neat leaves of leather fern, bound with rough brown twine. He comes a bit later, but he's here all the same, unfailingly steady, unspokenly supportive.

Grave feels like a generous term at the moment. It's their resting place, certainly, the two of them buried here together under the earth. But right now it's the beginning of winter so they can't lay new turf over the dirt, and there's no headstone yet since Phainon had been slow in getting that paperwork in. Instead there's a laminated tag staked at the foot of the burial plot with their names in neat handwriting. *Audata and Hieronymus Khaslana.*

They'd been given a good spot. Up on a hill overlooking the city, a couple of trees still clinging to some of their leaves and a white picket fence in view. All this grass, hundreds and hundreds of headstones around them. Some with flowers or other offerings. The air is stinging and fresh, and Mydei bends to lay the flowers in front of the tag beside the stalks of wheat Phainon brought. He doesn't speak as he straightens up, but it's nice just knowing he's there. Seeing the crease in his deep gray pants and the scuff on the toe of his dress shoe.

It's already starting to get dark. 5:46 at night, the sky more gray than blue with clouds. There's a streetlight a dozen paces away, but it hasn't come on yet. Phainon watches the last bits of the sunset fade out and breathes in. Breathes out. He turns to Mydei and his shiny red coat, his tiny braid, his lined eyes.

"Do you know why I brought wheat?" he asks.

Mydei's gaze meets his. They're standing kind of close, but he doesn't back up or look away. Just studies him, breath puffing up in the air. "They used to grow it, didn't they?"

Phainon nods, looks back at the dirt, that laminated tag. "Those wheat fields were everything to them," he says. "Even after they sold the farm because my dad got old and couldn't work in the field so much… that sound as it rustles in the wind is synonymous with home."

Mydei huffs, bumps their shoulders together. “That’s pretty poetic,” he notes. “Aren’t you embarrassed?”

Phainon just laughs. “You know, I wrote some poetry a few days ago, actually.”

“You would,” Mydei murmurs. His hands are stuffed in his pockets. The cloud of his breath dissipates in the air. “Well. I hope they like flowers too.”

“They do,” Phainon whispers. He shivers in the cold. Wets his chapped lips. “Thank you for coming.”

“You don’t need to thank me for every little thing.”

“I know.” He chuckles. “I don’t say it because I feel like I’m in your debt, I say it because it’s good to let people know that you notice the things they do for you.” A grunt in reply. Mydei grew up a bit colder than Phainon did. He doesn’t see compassion the same way. He wasn’t taught to love with everything in him. And yet he still does.

Phainon sinks down to sit in the grass. Cold, cold, cold. He sighs. “Oh no.”

“What is it?”

“The ground is wet,” Phainon answers. Mydei barks a laugh, and it’s good to see him smile, even here, even in the wake of this. Phainon knows he’s a bit harder to smile around lately. He grabs Mydei’s sleeve, pulls on it. “Come join me,” he says, “don’t be shy.”

“Fuck off,” Mydei tells him, still smiling, pulling free. But after a bit, a breath, he rolls his eyes and sits. His knee digs into Phainon’s thigh. Their shoulders brush. Phainon can do little but stare.

“You—”

“You’ve never been good at suffering alone,” Mydei says. He flicks Phainon’s leg before he can speak. “Shut up.”

“You’re crazy,” Phainon says, and laughs softly. Water soaks into his pants. Mydei’s too. The sky dims another shade. Mydei’s white roses almost look blue. And here he is at Phainon’s side. Steady and unyielding. “I love you.”

There it is again, that hitched breath, that moment of silence. “...So you’ve said.”

“Does it make you uncomfortable when I say it?” he asks.

Mydei wets his lips, keeps his gaze on the earth. “No,” he says, “I just…” Phainon stares. He sighs. “It’s an inappropriate time to ask.”

Slow, Phainon leans toward him. Drops his head on Mydei’s shoulder. Pokes him in the side. “Just say it.”

“I wonder how you mean it, is all,” Mydei murmurs. “Think nothing of it.”

“Is there a way you want me to mean it?” Phainon wonders. The surface of Mydei’s jacket is cold, not a bit of body heat to share. It smells like him, whatever that scent is. Phainon is sure he could poke around Mydei’s soaps and skincare to find out. “Or a way you don’t?”

“It’s an inappropriate time to ask,” Mydei repeats, but he pulls one of his hands out of his pocket to set it on Phainon’s head. His fingers are cold too, brushing the hot shell of his ear, carding through his hair.

There are a couple of things he could mean. Inappropriate to try and love him now, when he’s soft and fragile with grief. Inappropriate to crush his feelings and add another heartache on his already bowing back. Inappropriate for Phainon to ask for him now, when he’s pathetic and pitiable and hard to refuse.

“Alright,” Phainon murmurs, letting this go, weighing into him more heavily. Mydei’s palm cups the nape of his neck, fingers twisting in the longer bits of hair there. And whatever this is is enough, is plenty, and Phainon has never been the type to ask for more, more, more. Even if he wants it. Even if he’s loved Mydei for a while now.

A frigid breeze. His breath puffs warm in his face and leaves him cold. A little longer, and he sits back up, folding his arms around himself to keep warm, watching the tag on the grave try to shift in the wind, watching the wheat and the petals of Mydei's flowers sway. Mydei's hand floats, falls, rests in his lap. It's nice, having him here. Even if he's silent. Even if they can't share body heat.

He runs his fingers over the tag. *Audata and Heironymus Khaslana.* He misses them, misses them, misses them. Even now, after more than a week to adjust, to grow used to a life without his parents in it, he's still missing *something.* Hollow in his chest. Maybe he'll always be missing something. He doesn't think this kind of feeling is one that ever goes away.

Maybe he's just trying to fill in the gaps.

He shouldn't stay for long. His coat isn't warm like Mydei's. He's always been more for the sun than the stars. Suddenly, he wants nothing more than to go home and sleep for a day or two or ten.

But Mydei continues after being silent for a while. An exhale comes first. He fiddles with the edge of his sleeve. "You've got enough of your own shit to deal with," he says, "I don't want you carrying all of my feelings too."

And what is that? Reciprocation? Maybe Phainon is reading into things, but he's never been obtuse. *But I told you I loved you,* he thinks. *What would you be burdening me with?* Rejection is possible. Guilt for that, but no, Mydei has never been anything but honest, and he's warm. So warm when it comes to Phainon.

"Then…" He wets his lips. Looks at the flowers Mydei brought, thinks of the food he cooked, the red jacket that he lent, all the tiny favors. Maybe he's just a very good friend. He'd laugh if his heart weren't so heavy. "If you won't ask, can I?"

This time, Mydei's breath doesn't hitch. He's just quiet for a moment, two, and then he says, "You have your answers, if you're not too goddamn dense to see them."

He does laugh now, and feels a little lighter for it. A second time, he puts his head on Mydei's shoulder, the cold outside of his coat. "I see them," he whispers. "I promise I'm only a little bit stupid."

"You're—"

"I just hope you can see your answers too," he interrupts. There's a choked feeling in his throat. A warm one in his chest. He's so achingly lonely. He's never felt so supported in his life. His voice breaks on the next line. "I'm not half as good as you at showing it lately."

Mydei clears his throat, a little awkward. His arm comes around Phainon's shoulders. "...You're fine," he says. "You show way more than you think."

"Am I really so obvious?"

"I didn't realize you were trying to be mysterious." Again, Phainon laughs weakly. Mydei's fingers curl in the hair at the side of his neck. "Let me know when you're hungry," he says. "I'll make whatever you want."

"You spoil me," Phainon says, warm, warm, warm, freezing in his too-thin coat.

A sigh, a shake of the head. "I'm well aware."

△

He's home late, sated and sleepy and something other than lonesome. Bubbles yowls at him the moment he steps in the door, demanding to be fed, and as he dishes up a can of wet food, he can't help thinking it over and over again. *You and me. Us against the world, you stupid fucker.*

Bubbles is a messy eater. He acts like there's a timer going before his food is taken away, and there will be bits of meat on the kitchen floor that Phainon will have to wipe up when he's done, but all of his fight is gone. He watches this dumb cat, and he's left with a terribly stubborn affection as he showers and dresses for bed.

And there, when he comes out of the bathroom with wet hair and pajamas is a puddle of cat vomit. He barely manages not to step in it. As he stares at it and considers his options for clean up, a furry body brushes against his ankles. Bubbles chirps innocently, and after a quick inspection, begins to lick up his barf from the floor.

“Fucking— *No,* Bubbles; that’s disgusting.” He nudges the cat away with his foot and stumbles to the kitchen to get paper towels. He makes as much of a mess as he cleans up, cursing as he gets some on his hands. It takes a bit, but he manages, tossing the dirty paper towels out and wiping the patch of floor down with a disinfectant wipe. A voice in the back of his mind laughs, mocking, and says, *just wait until he throws up on the rug next time.*

He’s frustrated, but when he looks at Bubbles watching him from across the room, body tucked neatly into a loaf, he feels fond, fond, fond. How does that work? Why can’t he just cut his losses and let this menace of a cat go?

Just you and me now. Fuck.

He takes a picture of Bubbles, sends it to Mydei. *First time I give the bastard wet food and he throws it right up.*

He tosses his phone on the couch and adds a scoop of kibble to Bubbles’ bowl since he’s bound to be hungry after losing his dinner. Sure enough, he comes running as he hears the sound, meowing all raspy and getting right in Phainon’s way as he tries to set the bowl down.

“You’re so dumb,” he says aloud, whether to the cat or himself he doesn’t know. “Eat slowly this time.”

His phone dings. He sighs and folds over the arm of the sofa to get it. *He was excited,* Mydei sends. *Don’t pretend you don’t do the exact same thing.*

△

Friday comes. Work is similarly tiring and monotonous, but the thought of the weekend keeps Phainon going until he clocks out and collapses into the driver’s seat of his car with a sigh. And there it is. He made it, the same as

he had every week before the fire. The same as he will for the next forty years of his life until he can retire.

At home, he hangs up his work bag and his coat, takes off his shoes with Bubbles weaving between his feet like he wants to be stepped on, listening to that scratchy, hideous meow. He takes a long, boiling hot shower, comes out pink and pruny and hollow on the inside. His reflection is wan and bleary-eyed, hair wet and pasted to his forehead. Even that stubborn strand of hair that always sticks up stays down right now.

It's too early to sleep, but he climbs into bed and lays there, feeling like he's rotting from the inside out, staring at the ceiling. All this, and life still goes on. All this, and he just…

He sighs, he lives, he does what he can. Bubbles jumps onto the bed, meowing into Phainon's ear, nipping his elbow when he doesn't immediately get pets and attention. Phainon awkwardly pulls the cat onto his chest, staring into his wide blue eyes, dragging both hands down his furry back. Immediately, a rumble starts up under his palms. He sucks in a big breath against the weight on his chest. Bubbles shuts his eyes as Phainon scratches his head, perfectly content, smelling like cat food, and Phainon is still hollow and missing all his pieces.

"Do you miss them too?" he asks the cat. More purring. Bubbles tips into his hand, completely blissed out as Phainon rubs his knuckles into the thinner patches of fur in front of his ears. Softer, he whispers, "you have to wonder, don't you? Where did they go, why are you here? Do you understand any of it?"

He's been clingy since he got comfortable. Phainon doesn't think that's his default, going off his memories of the cat and what his parents would say. Bubbles never really purred, not for him. He rarely rubbed up against Phainon or sat in his lap or licked him. Maybe he just needs someone to give that affection to. Maybe he doesn't really care who the pets come from. Maybe Phainon is just projecting emotions far more complex and human on him than a cat has capacity for, but this feels like grief too. It feels like *missing,* like Bubbles is latching on to the first familiar thing because he's terrified of being left alone in the cold again.

Claws dig painfully into his skin as Bubbles starts to knead, so he takes those tiny paws between gentle fingers to stop them. Bubbles pulls his paws free, starts licking Phainon's hand instead. His breath is fishy. Phainon chuckles. "Maybe not. There isn't a thought in your dumb little head, is there?"

He pokes Bubbles' nose and is rewarded with an attempted bite to his finger. He does it again; Bubbles still misses. One more time, he takes a swat to the face and the cat stands up, weight painfully concentrated in his paws as he turns around, stepping right on a nipple and putting his butt in Phainon's face before he jumps off and disappears.

Phainon cups a hand over the pec that got stepped on, holding it there long after the faint pain fades. So tired, hollow renewed and gaping, he sighs and lets his eyes fall shut. Just for a little while, just to rest them. He'll get up when he can. Maybe he'll even cook himself something for dinner, but right now, he doesn't have the capacity for more than just this.

△

Saturday comes. Phainon tries to sleep in, but Bubbles wakes him up at six in the morning, demanding to be fed. He ignores the meowing and the whiskers in his face and the paws walking all over him for as long as he can before he drags himself up a bit before seven.

He feeds the cat, cleans the litterbox, gets himself a cup of yogurt from the fridge. He eats it on the couch, knees drawn up. The package says it expires in three days, and he still has four more of these uneaten that he'll have to finish.

His day is fairly uneventful. He sends Cipher more Bubbles photos, and she's probably seen the cat do the exact same pose from a dozen different angles by now, but she always reacts enthusiastically. Castorice sends some more poetry, something a bit more flowery than her usual style. As they talk for a while, he gets brave enough to send one of his own back.

Aglaea invites him a month and a half early to her Christmas party. Anaxa randomly texts him asking if "this statement is a lie" is true or false, and

Hyacine sends him an unsolicited picture of Little Ica's ass. It cracks him up before she sends a profuse apology barely a minute later saying she'd meant to send it to someone else, which cracks him up even harder.

It's honestly weird how many texts Phainon gets today. He's always had a lot of friends, a lot of *good* friends even, but… to have all these people here and waiting for him. Strange, strange, strange. He closes his phone with an odd feeling in his chest. Kind of warm. Maybe the opposite of lonely, whatever that is.

A knock on the door. He turns just to find Bubbles right up behind him, a tail under his heel, an angry yowl resounding, teeth in his ankle. He curses a half dozen times as he stumbles and the cat runs off. "Bubbles—!"

The bite didn't break skin, but his ankle still stings. A mix of annoyance and guilt floods him, and he follows the cat to his room, crouching to extend a hand under the bed in apology. Dilated blue eyes stare suspiciously back at him. "I'm sorry, bud," he murmurs. Bubbles sniffs him, begrudgingly allows a pet or two. "You brought that on yourself, you know. You can't stand behind people like that." He always does it, and he always gets stepped on, but he never learns.

Another knock, louder this time. Phainon sighs and hauls himself up to answer it.

And there's Mydei on the other side of the door. There's snow in his hair, wet on his boots. He's wearing that same red coat, a bag full of food in one hand. His eyes are red-lined and amber as ever. "Took you long enough. What was all the cussing?"

"I stepped on Bubbles," Phainon answers. His gaze dips, scans, lingers. He hasn't heard from Mydei in two days. He's fairly certain he hadn't missed a text. "Why are you here?"

Mydei lifts the bag, lifts an eyebrow. "Why do you think?"

"You made me food?"

“Congratulations, you have basic observational skills,” is the reply. “Are you going to let me in?”

Here he is. Here and waiting, as he always is, as he has been. Phainon takes a step back, opens the door a little wider. “I love you,” he says as Mydei passes. “Why are you *here?”*

He shuts the door. When he turns back around, Mydei is looking at him with this constipated expression. “Why do you *think?”* he repeats.

Phainon tries to smile, tries to joke, “You love me so much.”

But Mydei just stares, sighs. “Yeah,” he says. “I do.” Again, he lifts the bag. He’s trying for nonchalant, but there’s a flush in his face. Phainon’s mouth parts. “Did you already eat? I can just put it in the fridge for later.”

“No, I…” He wets his lips. His exhale is half a laugh. He doesn’t have a single reason to be surprised, but here he is. He follows Mydei to the kitchen. “...I’m pretty hungry now, actually.”

End Notes

in november of 2023 I lost someone very dear to me. I took in her cat after she'd been passed around from house to house and almost ended up in the animal shelter after spending a week alone in an empty apartment. she was the littlest thing with a meow like she smoked ten packs a day, the worst smelling poops I have ever had the misfortune of scooping, and a habit of sneezing directly in your face, but I loved her so goddamn much. she was 17, hard of hearing, had hyperthyroidism and kidney disease, and we had to put her down two weeks ago. this one is for her.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!